

If people only had 8 *fingers*
and *thumbs*, we'd probably
count in base eight



Some ancient
cultures used
their hands
to count in
base five

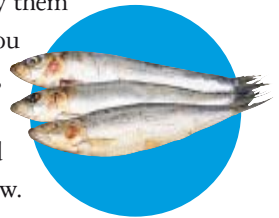
Can everyone count?

In a few places, people still live as hunter-gatherers. Most modern hunter-gatherers can count, but some **hardly bother**. The Pirahã tribe in the Amazon rain forest only **count to two** – all bigger numbers are “many”. In Tanzania, the Hadza tribe **count to three**. Both tribes manage fine without big numbers, which they never seem to need.



So why bother?

If people can live without numbers, why did anyone start counting? The main reason was to stop **cheats**. Imagine catching 10 fish and asking a friend to carry them home. If you couldn't count, your friend could **steal** some and you'd never know.



What's worth counting?

Even when people had invented counting and got used to the idea, they probably only counted things that seemed valuable. Some tribal people still do this. The Yupno people in Papua New Guinea count string bags, grass skirts, pigs, and money, but not days, people, sweet potatoes, or nuts!

